

{ŪVr`m@Úm`... - gm>>¶¶mJ...

Chapter 2 – The Path of Doctrines

Chapter Introduction: This chapter of 72 verses is termed *Sankhya Yoga* (The Path of Doctrines). In this chapter, the Lord answers Arjuna's basic questions about the purpose of life and other related philosophical concepts. Sensing that Arjuna's reservations about fighting the war were due to his fear of losing his loved ones, the Lord delves into the nature of individual souls, the indestructibility of souls, the relationship between individual souls and Himself. He reminds Arjuna that He gave human forms to individual souls to help them in their spiritual journey and that everyone must play their dutiful role in society. In verses 2.12 to 2.39, the Lord lectures on the nature of individual souls and the Supreme soul (Lord Almighty). In verse 2.39, the Lord tells Arjuna how to acquire divine, spiritual knowledge which is explained in brief in verses 2.45 to 2.51. In these verses, the Lord discusses the concept of *nishkama karma*, that is, performing prescribed duties without expectations. The Lord urges Arjuna not to despair over the hurt that may be caused to his elders and teachers in the war, as they had chosen to support the evil king Duryodhana and reminds Arjuna that he had an obligation to fight this just war to protect his citizens. Lord Krishna teaches Arjuna to focus on performing his prescribed duty of protecting his citizens as an offering to the Lord Almighty and not let his emotions come in the way. Chapter 2 can be considered the foundational chapter of the entire **Gita** as it answers Arjuna's (and through Arjuna, everyone's) basic questions about the purpose of life. The remaining chapters serve to expand on the concepts presented in this chapter.

gO`CdM -

V VWm H\$ n`m@{di` A l nUmH\$b j U_ &

{dfrXV{X dmŠ`_CdM_YgXZ... && 1 &&

Sanjaya said: Lord Madhusoodana said the following to grief-stricken Arjuna who was overcome with self-pity and had tears in his eyes. (2.1)

Comments: Sensing Dhrutarashtra's curiosity as to the events that follow Arjuna's dropping of his weapons, Sanjaya continues with his narration of the next set of events starting with Lord Krishna's questioning of Arjuna's actions.

Arjuna, Rise Up and Wage this Just War

Ir^JdmZdmM Ĩ&
H\$VñĒdm H\$í_b{X {df_g 'npñWV_ Ĩ&
AZm`Oĩ\_ñd½`_ AH\$s{VH\$a_OZ Ĩ&& 2 Ĩ&&

The Lord said: O Arjuna! What caused this delusion for you to give up your duties at the time of crisis? This is not expected of wise men, it does not lead to glory, or heavens and it only brings disrepute. (2.2)

Comments: By stating that Arjuna is uttering words unworthy of wise men, Lord Krishna is giving a hint of the concept of '*prajnavada*' which will be elaborated in verse 2.11.

Šbã`\_m ñ\_J\_... nmW ZVîdæ`nnÚV Ĩ&
jĐ öX`Xm~ë` Ē`ŠĒdm{Îmĩ} naYVn Ĩ&& 3 Ĩ&&

O Partha! Do not yield to weakness. This is not worthy of you. O Parantapa (Destroyer of enemies)! Get rid of your heart's weakness, get up and get ready to wage this war. (2.3)

Comments: Krishna asking Arjuna to get up has both literal and figurative meanings. In verse 1.47, it was noted that Arjuna was sitting still in his chariot, refusing to wage the war. Now Krishna is directing Arjuna to

get out of his chariot and wage the just war. It also indicates the need to get into action in pursuance of one's duty. Krishna also refers to Arjuna as *Parantapa* (destroyer of enemies), to remind him that he has waged and won many wars earlier and need not be afraid to fight this war.

Arjuna's Dilemma and Surrender to Krishna

AOZ CdmM Ĩ&
H\$W ^rĥ__h g»` ĦmU M _YgXZ Ĩ&
Bf{^... à{V`mĔñ`m{ _ nOmhd[agXZ Ĩ&& 4 Ĩ&&

Arjuna said: O Madhusoodana (Annihilator of demon Madhu)! How can I direct my arrows at Bheeshma and Drona who are worthy of worship? (2.4)

Comments: Arjuna who is overcome with grief and emotion is not able to relate to Krishna's advice and reiterates his position in 5 verses. Arjuna indicates that even if he were to approach the war as a duty, he could not hurl his arrows at Bheeshma and Drona who have taught him much and are worthy of worship.

Jê\$ZhĔdm {h _hmZ^mdnZ I`m ^m°\$ ^ú`_nrh bmH\$ Ĩ&
hĔdm@WH\$m _mřV Jê\$Zhd ^ÄOr` ^mJmZ é{Yaà{X½YmZ Ĩ&& 5 Ĩ&&

It is better to live by begging for alms than kill our great teachers. How can one enjoy the luxuries of a kingdom attained by waging a war and spilling the blood of these teachers who are of great eminence? (2.5)

Comments: Arjuna argues that it is not worth winning the war which would entail killing his elders and teachers who are pious and God fearing, as that would not lead to any joy in this world and would bring difficulties hereafter also. A better option would be to give up fighting and live by begging for alms.

Z MV{ÛÙ... H\$VaPm Jar`m `Ûm O`\_`{X dm Zm O`>`...`&
 `mZd hEdm Z {OOr{dfm\_ñV@dpñWVm... à\_ I YmVamim...`&& 6 &&

I do not know which is better, that we win, or they win over us. We do not desire to live by killing the sons of Dhrutarashtra who are standing in front of us. (2.6)

Comments: Arjuna argues that if he wins the war by killing the Kauravas, it is in a way equivalent to losing, as the war would also entail the death of many near and dear ones. Arjuna, thus is not able to decide the better option. Prior to this verse, Arjuna seemed to have made up his mind that he would not wage the war, but now after reflecting on Krishna's advice he is weighing both the options.

H\$mñÊ`XmfmnhVñd^md... nÀNm{`Edm Y_gâ_TMVm...`&
 `ÀN`... ñ`m{p{üV~{h VÍ\_ {eî`ñV@h em{Y_m Edm ànp_`&& 7`&&

My natural valor is subdued due to compassion. My mind is conflicted on the issue of duty. I am asking you. Which is the path for ultimate good? I am your disciple. I surrender to you. Please guide me. (2.7)

Comments: Arjuna is clearly conflicted and is not able to make up his mind. He surrenders to Krishna and asks for Krishna's guidance.

Z {h àní`m{`__mnZÚmX `ÀNmH\$\_ÀNmFU{pYĐ`mUm_`&
 Admß`^\_mdgnEZ\_Õ amÁ`gamUm_{n Mm{YnÊ`\_`&& 8`&&

Even if I achieve unchallenged ownership of this prosperous world here, and supremacy over the deities in the upper worlds hereafter, I cannot see how I can dispel this grief which is draining my senses. (2.8)

Comments: Here again we see that Arjuna is conflicted. He declares that even if he were to follow his prescribed duties and wage the war to protect the citizens from the evil Kauravas, and even if his actions result in him accruing enough good credits to become the leader of heavens, he would be unable to control his grief over the prospect of losing near and dear ones.

gO` CdM M ĩ&
Ed_ŠEdm öfrH\$e JSmH\$e... naYVn... ĩ&
Z `mĒñ` h{V Jm{dYX_ CŠEdm VĩUt ~^d h ĩ&& 9 &&

Sanjaya said: Gudakesha (Arjuna, the one who has conquered sleep), Parantapa (Arjuna - the destroyer of enemies), thus addressed Govinda, (Krishna - the controller of senses). Saying that he would not fight the war (as he is conflicted), he became silent. (2.9)

Comments: Arjuna is referred to as Gudakesha – the one who has conquered sleep. Sleep, along with lethargy represents *tamas* or ignorance. Arjuna has won over these and hence is eligible to receive the sermon from the Lord. Further, Arjuna is termed *Parantapa*, the one who has destroyed enemies in many wars. Sri Rayaru in GV draws attention to the use of the term ‘*ha*’ which indicates surprise. Sanjaya seems to be indicating that it was a surprise to him that Arjuna with such qualities, was in a despondent mood.

V_dmM öfrH\$e... àhg{Pd ^maV ĩ&
gZ`mé^`m_Ü` {dfrXV{X dM... ĩ&& 10 ĩ&&

O Dhritarashtra of the Bharata dynasty! Lord Hrishikesha smilingly said the following words to the grief-stricken Arjuna who was in the middle of the armies. (2.10)

Comments: Krishna’s smile is a rhetorical reaction to the inconsistent position that Arjuna had placed himself in.

The Soul is Eternal, The Body is Perishable

Ir^JdmZdmM ĩ&
 AemÀ`mZÝdemMñĒEd àkndmXmü ^mfg ĩ&
 JVngZJVmgü ZmZemMpÝV npÊSVm... ĩ&& 11 ĩ&&

The Lord said: You are grieving over those who do not deserve sympathy and saying whatever is coming to your mind. Learned ones do not grieve over those who are about to die just as they do not grieve over those living. (2.11)

Comments: Elders and teachers such as Bheeshma and Drona, even though worthy of worship, were on the side of evil and so Arjuna should not have been grieving over their impending death. Krishna uses the word ‘*Prajnaavada*’ which has two meanings – one who says whatever that comes to one’s mind and secondly, one whose words are not acceptable to the wise.

Z Ēddmh OmV Zmg Z Ēd Z_ OZmYnm... ĩ&
 Z Md Z ^{dî`m\_ gd d`_V... na_ ĩ&& 12 ĩ&&

There was no time when neither Me nor you nor any of these kings here did not exist. Even in future there will be no time when any of us will cease to exist. (2.12)

Comments: Krishna goes on to answer three conflicts in Arjuna’s mind which are causing him distress. Is the distress due to a fear of the loss of souls of loved ones? Or is it due to a fear of the loss of their physical bodies? Or is it due to a fear of the loss of their bodies which are equated to their souls?

He answers the first question in this verse where he categorically states that souls are eternal and have no beginning or end. This applies to

Arjuna, to all kings assembled at the warfront (and by extension everyone) and especially to the Lord Almighty, which is indicated using the word ‘*tu*’.

The fact that the Lord is especially eternal is supported by scriptures such as **Katha Upanishad (2.5.13)** which describes the Lord as ‘*nityo nityanam*’ (He is eternal among eternal). While the individual souls are eternal, the Lord’s eternality is superior to that of individual souls. Living beings whose souls are eternal do undergo creation and destruction of their physical bodies (birth and death), but the Lord who has a transcendental body does not experience creation or destruction. Hence, He is said to have superior eternality compared to individual souls. The other two questions are answered in later verses 2.13 and 2.20.

A question that arises at this stage is - how could Arjuna, himself a realized soul as an incarnation of deity Devendra, the king of all deities, harbour such doubts about the nature of the Lord? Sri Madhwacharya answers this question [GTN] by stating that the Lord in the form of Vedavyasa in the great epic **Mahabharata** elaborates the sermon in more detail for the benefit of humanity.

X{hZm@pñ_Z`Wm Xh H\$m\_ma`mdZ Oam V&
VWm XhmYVaàm{áYuañVÌ Z_ø{V V&& 13 V&&

Just as one experiences childhood, youth, and old age, one similarly experiences attainment of another body. So, the wise ones do not grieve over the loss of the physical body. (2.13)

Comments: While the verse 2.12 deals with the issue of a soul’s nature, in this verse the Lord describes the nature of one’s physical body. Just as one goes through changes in the physical body in one’s lifetime, death is inevitable in the end. Hence Arjuna has no reason to grieve over the loss of the physical bodies of his loved ones in a just war.

Attachment Causes Misery

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
 अर्जुन उवाच ॥ ननु भगवांन्मया ह्यथवा न ॥
 त्वयि कथं भगवन्मया ह्यथवा न ॥ १४ ॥

Do sense organs and sensory objects cause one to experience cold or heat, happiness, or sadness? No. One experiences temporary happiness or sadness when these are accompanied by attachment. O Bharata! Rid yourself of attachment which is the real reason for happiness or sadness. (2.14)

Comments: If Arjuna's distress is due to him not being able to interact with his near and dear ones after they die in war, the Lord states that such distress is due to attachment. Interaction of sense organs with sensory objects does not in itself cause happiness or sadness. It is only when such interaction is accompanied by attachment to the physical body does one experience happiness or sadness. Krishna uses the example of heat and cold as sensory objects that cause pleasure or misery when they encounter one's skin (the only sense organ that covers one's entire body). A cool breeze in summer may cause pleasure but the same breeze in winter would cause discomfort. The difference is because of one's attachment to the body. Again, when one is asleep one does not feel distress in the presence of an object that would emit an unpleasant sound. However, when that person is awake the same sound would be objectionable. Krishna advises Arjuna to wage the just war and rid himself of attachment to his loved ones which is causing him distress.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ।
 अर्जुन उवाच ॥ ननु भगवांन्मया ह्यथवा न ॥
 त्वयि कथं भगवन्मया ह्यथवा न ॥ १५ ॥

O Arjuna, Superior among men! One, who is equipoised in happiness or sadness caused due to attachment to sense organs and sense objects, is indeed eligible for liberation. (2.15)

Comments: Arjuna could argue that one way for him to avoid distress would be to avoid waging the war which could result in loss of loved ones. In this case, the issue of attachment does not arise. So, why not avoid the war? Lord Krishna says that waging a just war is Arjuna's duty and the way that Arjuna can avoid distress is by ridding himself of attachment to his near and dear ones. Such an action will also result in Arjuna achieving liberation hereafter.

ZṁgVṁ {dÚV@^ṁdṁ Zṁ^ṁdṁ {dÚV gV... ṽ&
C^`ṁa{n Ñ`iṁ@ÝVñĒdZ`ṁñVîdX{e{^... ṽ&& 16 ṽ&&

No good comes out of bad deeds. Also, there are no bad results from good deeds. The learned seers who have realized the Lord Almighty are convinced of these two facts. (2.16)

Comments: Arjuna has expressed concern that he will incur sins by killing elders and teachers during the war. However, these elders are on the side of evil and it is Arjuna's duty to fight for justice. In this verse, Krishna says that no sin is incurred by performing good deeds.

There is a second meaning to this verse as stated by Sri Rayaru [GV]- Inert nature is not subject to creation and destruction, and hence is eternal. The Lord Almighty is also eternal and indestructible. These two concepts have been traditionally taught by knowledgeable seers.

How can one say that inert matter and the Lord Almighty are eternal, and not subject to creation and dissolution? Sri Rayaru [GV] provides an answer by referring to the first line of this verse where - *asat* refers to prime material nature, *sat* refers to the Lord Almighty, *abhava* refers to *prag abhava* and *pradhwamsa abhava*, and *na vidyate* means 'does not exist'. This means that prime matter and the Lord Almighty do not have the conditions of the above *abhava* twins. Thus, the two entities are said to be eternal.

What are the *abhava* twins? This can be explained with an example. Before a potter creates a pot out of clay, the pot is said to have the condition of prior non-existence (*prag abhava*). When such a pot is destroyed, the pot is in the condition of post non-existence (*pradhwamsa abhava*). The material cause for the creation of the universe is inert nature. The Lord Almighty is the instrumental cause for the creation of the universe. Inert nature and the Lord Almighty are not subject to the conditions of prior non-existence (*prag abhava*) and post non-existence (*pradhwamsa abhava*), and thus are not subject to creation or destruction.

Sri Rayaru [GV] quotes Sri Narahari Teertha [GBBPN] who in his commentary on the **Gita** had an additional interpretation for the use of the word ‘*api*’ (meaning ‘also’) in this verse. This word when combined with the phrase ‘learned seers’, implies that the eternality of inert nature and the Lord Almighty is known through the traditional teachings of learned seers and through scriptural evidence from the epic **Vishnu Purana**.

Sri Vishwesha Teertha in his **Gita Saroddhara** [GS] provides a third interpretation for the first line in this verse by applying the concepts to living beings – the physical body that is subject to birth is not perishable (as it is perishable) and the unborn soul does not perish.

Eternal, Indestructible Soul reflects the Lord

A{dZm{e V VX{d{Ö `Z gd{ X WV_ i&
{dZme_ i` `ñ` mñ` Z H\$(üV H\$V_h{V i&& 17 i&&

Know that entities that pervade the universe will not perish. No one can cause destruction to the imperishable. (2.17)

Comments: The entities referred to are not subject to decay and hence are imperishable and eternal. These entities include the Lord Almighty, individual souls, space (*avyakrita akasha*) and the letters (the 51 letters in the Sanskrit alphabet). Space is known as *avyakrita akasha* as it

does not undergo transformation during creation or dissolution. It is single, eternal, and self-supporting.

A'Vd'V B_ Xhm {ZÈ`ñ`m°\$m... ear[aU... Ý&
AZm{eZm@à_`ñ` Vñ_mX ¶Ü`ñd ^maV Ý&& 18 &&

O Bharata! It is said that the eternal soul's visible physical body is perishable, but the Lord Almighty, the Supreme Soul, is imperishable (not subject to four-way destruction). Hence, fight this war as worship to the indwelling Lord Aprameya, the one who is not limited by space, time, or attributes. (2.18)

Comments: The individual soul is a reflection of the Lord as in a mirror. Some argue that when the mirror which they consider is *upadhi* (the conditioning medium) is destroyed, the reflection no longer exists. Sri Rayaru [GV] explains that the *upadhi* in the example of a reflection in the mirror is the intrinsic body of the individual soul and not the physical body. The intrinsic body (*swaroopa deha*) of a soul never perishes. The Lord is eternal, has no blemishes, does not experience decay or destruction of body, as His body is transcendental. The individual soul's intrinsic body is also indestructible, and in that sense, the individual soul is deemed to have some similarity with the Lord. Hence the intrinsic body of the individual soul is the *upadhi* in the example of comparing the Lord and the individual soul to the original and the mirror reflection. Also, if the Lord Almighty and individual souls have similar attributes such as indestructibility, then why should one perform duties as a worship to the Lord? Firstly, the individual soul is dependent on the Lord and secondly, the Lord has special characteristics far and beyond those of individual souls. The Lord pervades everywhere. Sri Rayaru also states [GV] that the Lord is not subject to the fourfold destruction – (i) of the body (as His body is transcendental), (ii) of the soul (as He is eternal), (iii) of attributes (as He is full of infinite auspicious attributes and is devoid of any blemishes) and (iv) of happiness (as He is devoid of misery). He is superior to individual souls and hence is worthy of worship.

`EZ d{Îm hÝVma `üZ _Ý`V hV_ Ý&
 C^m Vm Z {dOmZrVm Zm `hpÝV Z hÝ`V Ý&& 19 &&

One who thinks that one person has killed another person and the one who thinks that the second person has been killed - neither has true knowledge. No one can kill anyone else, and no one can be killed. (2.19)

Comments: Arjuna's distress is premised on his assumption that he may kill his elders and teachers in the war. However, no one can independently kill someone or get killed by someone. Further, no one experiences destruction of their soul, and the Lord is the only independent entity. Hence, Arjuna's grief is misplaced.

Z Om`V {`V dm H\$Xm{Mp` ^Edm ^{dVm dm Z ^` ... Ý&
 AOm {ZÈ` ... emceVm@` namUm Z hÝ`V hÝ`_mZ eara Ý&& 20 Ý&&

The soul is not subject to birth and death; it is eternal. It is not that the soul did not exist earlier and was born. It has no birth as it is eternal, and it is not subject to decay. Even when the physical body is destroyed, the soul does not perish. (2.20)

Comments: This verse has origins in the **Katha Upanishat** and provides the scriptural reference to the concepts in the previous verse.

A second interpretation of this verse is as follows: The Lord does not experience bodily birth and death. All His incarnations such as Rama and Krishna are eternal, and from time to time He manifests Himself and makes Himself visible or invisible. The aspect of the Lord manifesting and making Himself visible is generally termed as His birth.

Many scriptures have references to the Lord being in the womb of His mother (for example Krishna being in the womb of Devaki) before being born. The Lord's existence in the womb is incidental to the storyline

where the Lord continues to exist with infinite auspicious attributes and His condition is not like that of mortals who suffer in their mother's womb.

dxm{dzm{ez {ZĒ` ` EZ_O_ì` ` ĩ&
H\$W g néf... nmW H\$ KmV`{V hpÝV H\$ _ ĩ&& 21 ĩ&&

O Partha! One who knows that the soul is eternal, that it does not perish, that it has no birth or death; how can that person cause death to someone and/or kill someone. (2.21)

Comments: The word ‘vinasha’ also means weakness such as hatred which is caused by attachment. The soul does not have these defects intrinsically, but a person gets them due to attachment. A wise person who does not have such defects (*avinashi*) will know the true nature of individual souls and the Supreme Soul and will know that no one can cause death to someone else.

dmgm{g OrUm{Z `Wm {dhm` Zd{Z J+m{V Zam@nam{U &
VWm earam{U {dhm` OrUmÝ`Ý`m{Z g`m{V Zd{Z Xhr ĩ&& 22 ĩ&&

Just as a person lets go of worn-out old clothes and adorns new clothes, a soul leaves a decaying body and takes on a new body. (2.22)

Comments: In this verse, there is further confirmation on the separation of the soul and the physical body. In verse 2.13, it was stated that a soul experiences transformation in a physical body as a person transitions through childhood, youth, adulthood, and old age. However, that was related to the same physical body. In this verse, it is clarified that the same soul will migrate from a decayed body to a new body, just as one discards old, worn-out clothes and replaces them with new, good clothes.

ZZ {NÝXpÝV eó{U ZZ Xh{V nmdH\$... ĩ&
Z MZ ŠbX`ÝĒ`mnm Z emf`{V _éV... ĩ&& 23 ĩ&&

Weapons cannot cut the soul, fire cannot burn the soul, water cannot wet the soul and wind cannot parch the soul. (2.23)

Comments: While it was made clear that the intrinsic body of a soul does not decay or get destroyed over time, some can question whether it would be possible to harm or destroy a soul with physical elements such as weapons (made from mining earth), fire, water, wind etc. In this verse it is clarified that it is not possible to harm or destroy a soul by any of these means. Further, as clarified by Sri Rayaru [GV], it is also not possible to destroy a soul through a curse (as in the episode of *Daksha Prajapati* having his head chopped off due to a curse, there was no destruction of his soul).

AÀNÚ@`\_Xmø@`_AŠbÚ@emî`Ed M Ĩ&
{ZĚ`...gdJV...ñWmUaMb@`gZmVZ...Ĩ&& 24 Ĩ&&

The soul cannot be cut, cannot be burnt, cannot be drowned, and cannot be parched. The soul is eternal, atomic in size, and exists under the purview of the immutable, omnipresent Lord (who is known through the **Vedas**). (2.24)

Comments: The previous verse (2.23) refers to a soul's indestructible nature in current time as well as in the past. This verse further clarifies that a soul's indestructible nature applies to future time also.

Aì`°\$m@`_{MYĚ`m@`_A{dH\$m`m@`_À`V Ĩ&
Vñ_mXd {d{XĚdZ ZmZe{MV_h{g Ĩ&& 25 Ĩ&&

The scriptures say that The Lord cannot be visualized by sense organs, He cannot be comprehended, and He is not subject to decay. Arjuna, knowing this you should focus on performing your duty as an offering to the Lord and quit grieving. (2.25)

Comments: The previous verse indicated that the Lord is omnipresent. If so, and if the Lord is resident in all beings, then why is He not visible? This verse answers this question by stating that no one can comprehend the Lord's attributes and that He is also capable of possessing contradictory attributes.

AW MZ {ZĚ`OmV {ZĚ` d m _Y`g _V_ Ĩ&
VWm@{n Ěd _hm~mhm ZZ em{MV_h{g Ĩ&& 26 Ĩ&&

OmVñ` {h Ydm \_Ě`Yd OY`\_Vñ` M Ĩ&
Vñ_mXn[ahm`@W Z Ěd em{MV_h{g Ĩ&& 27 Ĩ&&

O Arjuna (one with strong arms)! When you know that living beings are born and will inevitably die, there is no point in grieving over them. (2.26)

Death is certain for anyone born and likewise rebirth is certain for anyone dead. There is no point in grieving over an issue that has no solution. (2.27)

Comments: The soul does not perish. However, Arjuna could argue that the loss of the physical bodies of dear ones can also cause grief, as he would not be able to see them. Verse 2.27 answers this question by stating that birth and death of physical bodies is inevitable for everyone and there is no point in grieving over this issue that has no solution.

Aì`°\$mXr{Z ^Vm{Z ì`°\$_Ü`m{Z ^maV Ĩ&
Aì`°\${ZYZmY`d VÌ H\$m n[aXdZm Ĩ&& 28 Ĩ&&

O Bharata! Living beings get a body between birth and death from inert, material nature and the body will merge back with inert nature after death. Why grieve over such a body? (2.28)

Comments: While it was made clear that everyone experiences birth and death due to their physical bodies, what causes birth and death? This verse reveals that birth and death are caused by interaction with material nature. The physical body is made up of a certain proportion of the five basic elements of nature. When a soul gets a body from material nature it is termed as birth, and when it loses the body and is back to material nature, it is termed as death. A soul that is dependent on the Lord has no control over the process of birth and death. So, it is not worth grieving over such a temporary body.

After conquering the snake Kalinga, Krishna and other yadavas were spending a night in the forest. They were faced with the onset of rapidly approaching forest fire. Lord Krishna extinguished this fire by swallowing it. Saint Sri Vadiraja [RV] describes this incident to explain the fact that all elements of nature emanate from the Lord and submerge back into Him.

Amü`dV ní`{V H\$[üXZ_mü`dX dX{V VWd MmÝ`... Ý&
Amü`d f Z\_Ý`... eUm{V IEdm@ß`Z dX Z Md H\$üV Ý&& 29 Ý&&

Some look at the Lord in amazement. Some talk about Him in amazement. Some hear about Him in amazement. No one can completely understand Him even after hearing a lot about Him. (2.29)

Comments: While it was made clear previously that individual souls are not independent, one can ask who they are dependent on. This verse explains that the sole independent entity in the universe is the Lord Almighty. It also answers that there are no other independent entities that can equal the Lord. While many people can claim to know the attributes of the Lord, this verse makes it clear that only some visualize the Lord with amazement. Just as one cannot find any comparison to the sky or the ocean, no one can find any comparison to the Lord. He is truly incomparable. For one to get over grief that may arise from any activity, one must focus on performing one's duty as an offering to the Lord. So, it is important for one to appreciate the true greatness of the Lord.

Xhr {ZĚ`\_dÜ`m@` Xh gdñ` ^maV ĩ&
Vñ_mV gd{U ^V{Z Z Ěd e{MV_h{g ĩ&& 30ĩ&&

O Bharata! The soul inside the physical body cannot be destroyed even if the physical body perishes (as it is protected by the Lord). So, there is no need to grieve over anyone. (2.30)

Comments: In verse 2.12, it was stated that the individual souls are also by their nature eternal. How then can one say that they are dependent on the Lord? Sri Rayaru [GV] explains that the Lord protects and controls all bodies that envelope an individual soul, namely – the intrinsic body (*swaroopa deha*), the subtle body (*linga deha*) and the gross physical body (*sthoola deha*). This verse thus explains another aspect of the Lord's greatness.

Fighting a Just War is Arjuna's Duty

ñdY__ {n Mmdú` Z {dH\$pañV_h{g ĩ&
Yá`m{Ō `ŌmÀN`m@Y`V j {İ`ñ` Z {dÚV ĩ&&31ĩ&

Knowing that fighting a just war is your duty, there is no need for you to be shaken. For a person hailing from a ruling (*kshatriya*) class, there is no loftier duty than fighting for a just cause. (2.31)

Comments: In verse 1.29, Arjuna had said that he was trembling as he was overcome with grief. In this verse, the Lord responds to that condition. Previously He had declared that Arjuna need not grieve over the loss of near and dear ones as their souls never perish. Now Krishna says that in addition, it is Arjuna's compulsory duty to fight the Kauravas to end their misrule and there is nothing more important than this. Thus, there is absolutely no need for Arjuna to feel weak and helpless.

`ÑÀN` m MmnnP ñdJÛma_nmdV_`&
g{ I Z... j{Ì`m... nmW b^YV `Õ_rÑe_`&& 32`&&

O Partha! Blessed are those in the *kshatriya* class who get an opportunity to do the right deed by fighting for a just cause. This opens the doors for heavens hereafter. (2.32)

Comments: Not all kshatriyas get an opportunity to wage a just war. So, when such an opportunity has been given to Arjuna without any effort (and by the Grace of the Lord), he should embrace the opportunity which would open for him the doors to heavens hereafter.

AW MV Èd{` Yâ¶ gJm` Z H\$[aî`{g`&
VV... ñdY_` H\$s{V M {hÈdm nm\_n\_dmbñ`{g`&& 33`&&

In case you decide to relinquish your responsibility to fight for a just cause, you will be guilty of abdicating duty, you will suffer loss of reputation here and accrue sins. (2.33)

Comments: To convince Arjuna that it is a duty, not an option, for him to fight the war, Krishna now indicates the outcome for Arjuna if he does not fight. Arjuna would suffer loss of reputation in this world and accrue sins for abdicating his responsibility, with consequences hereafter.

AH\$s{V Mm{n ^Vm{Z H\$W{`î`pYV V@î``m_`&
gâ^m{dVñ` MmH\$s{V\_aUmX{V[aÀ`V`&& 34`&&

Everyone will talk about your loss of reputation and for a worthy person, loss of reputation is more dreadful than death. (2.34)

Comments: Krishna indicates that the negative effect of refusing to fight is permanent loss of reputation. For someone who is revered among professional peers, a loss of reputation can be worse than defeat and death.

^`mXaUmXnaV \_ñ`ÝV Ěd m _hmaWm... Ý&
 `f m M Ěd ~h \_V m ^Ěd m `mñ`{g b mKd _ Ý&& 35 Ý&&

Great warriors will conclude that you ran away from the battlefield as you were afraid to fight. You will be disgraced in front of those who hold you in great esteem. (2.35)

Comments: This verse responds to Arjuna's argument that his opposition to fighting the war was due to his compassion and not due to fear of losing. Krishna says that Arjuna was held in high esteem as a great warrior based on his winning many battles, and other great warriors can now conclude that Arjuna ran away from the war as he was afraid of facing them. After all, many other participants in this war (on both sides) would also lose their near and dear ones and they had not backed away.

AdmÀ`d mXmü ~hZ d{Xî`pÝV Vd m{hV m... Ý&
 {ZÝXÝVñVd g m _İ` V m X... I Va Z {H\$` Ý&& 36 Ý&&

Your enemies will talk disparagingly about your valor in many unspeakable ways. What is more dreadful than this? (2.36)

Comments: To further convince Arjuna of the perils of backing away from fighting, Krishna says that in addition to other great warriors assembled there, many enemies of Arjuna whom he had defeated earlier could now conclude and spread the word that Arjuna was incapable of fighting a war. This could be extremely insulting, especially for a *kshatriya*.

hV m d m àmßñŦ{g ñdJ {OĚd m d m ^mú`g _hr _ Ý&
 Vñ _mX{Îmð H\$mÝV` `Ōm` H\$V{Zü`... Ý&& 37 Ý&&

If you fight and die in this battle, you are sure to reach heaven. If you win, you will rule this world. O Son of Kunti! Rise up and fight this battle with strong determination. (2.37)

Comments: In verse 2.6, Arjuna had expressed his doubt about whether it was better for the Pandavas to win the war or for the Kauravas to win. Krishna responds to that doubt here. After discussing the impact on Arjuna's reputation for backing away from a just war, Krishna now goes on to convince him that he is in a win-win situation and has nothing to lose by fighting the war. If Arjuna were to win this war, he would get back the kingdom and reach heavens hereafter for adhering to his duties. If he were to lose the war and die, he would surely reach the heavens for his efforts in fighting the evil. Either way, he wins.

g l X... l g_ H\$Edm bm^mbm^m O`mO`m y&
VWm `Öm `Á`ñd Zd nmn'dmßñ`{g y&& 38 &&

Treat happiness and sadness, profit and loss, victory and defeat with equipoise and fight for justice. You will not be tainted with sin. (2.38)

Comments: In verse 1.36, Arjuna says that he may accrue sins by fighting the war, as that would result in loss of life to many. Krishna answers that point by stating that performing one's prescribed duty as an offering to the Lord will not attract sins and in fact will help accrue positive credit. One must treat with equanimity - happiness and sadness, profit, loss, victory and defeat in all actions and perform them as offerings to the Lord. Arjuna must get over any sadness due to the loss of near and dear ones and focus on performing his duty.

Instrument to Acquire Knowledge

Efm V@{^hVm gm>>`~{Ö`mJ pEd_m eU y&
~Öçm `°\$m ``m nmW H\$_~Y àhmn`{g y&& 39&&

O Partha! You have been told about the nature of *Sankhya* (knowledge) so far. Now listen to the ways (*yoga*) to achieve that knowledge which will free you from bondage. (2.39)

Comments: From verses 2.12 to 2.38, Krishna gives Arjuna knowledge (*sankhya*) about the Lord and the individual souls. From now on, He teaches Arjuna the methods and procedures of acquiring such knowledge after which Arjuna would be able to perform his prescribed duties with conviction, realize the Lord, get over worldly bondage and achieve the state of eternal bliss (*moksha*). While previous verses discussed the nature of individual souls and briefly, the nature of the Supreme Lord, from now on till the end of Chapter 6, more details about the methods and procedures to learn about the nature of the Lord are provided. Also, so far, Krishna had addressed Arjuna's specific situation, and from now on, the teachings would turn generic in that they would apply to the whole of mankind.

Zhm{^H\$_Zmem@pñV àĒ`dm`m Z {dÚV Ĩ&
ñdēn_β`ñ`Y_ñ`Ìm`V_hVm ^`mV Ĩ&& 40 &&

Even if one falters in the beginning during the learning of this spiritual knowledge, no effort is wasted. Even a little sincere effort will protect one from great peril. (2.40)

Comments: This verse answers the doubts that some may have about the efforts required to achieve spiritual knowledge. Given the significant efforts required, what would happen if one could not complete the task? The Lord states that no effort is wasted. Even if someone starts the process and for some reason gets interrupted, the efforts will yield positive results. Any sincere effort will please the Lord and through His grace one will be able to achieve spiritual awakening.

ì`dgm`mpĒ_H\$m ~{ŌaH\$h H\$éZÝXZ Ĩ&
~hem I m øZÝVmü ~Ō`m@ì`dgm{`Zm` Ĩ&& 41 Ĩ&&

O Scion of the Kuru Dynasty (Arjuna)! There is only one teaching that leads to decisive spiritual knowledge. There are endless teachings that lead the undecided ones to diverse, wrong knowledge. (2.41)

Comments: There are different teachings (often contradictory) about spiritual knowledge. How then does one know the true path? Krishna in this verse categorically states that only true teaching leads to proper divine and spiritual knowledge. This is based on evidence from revered spiritual texts such as the **Vedas** and is realized from following the Vaishnava path which enunciates the supremacy of Lord Vishnu as the supreme of all souls. In the next few verses (from 2.41 to 2.46), the Lord clears any doubts about the true purport of the **Vedas**.

It is interesting to note that the Lord refers to Arjuna as Kurunandana, meaning ‘Scion of the Kuru dynasty who would bring joy to his lineage’, probably implying that most of the descendants of the Kuru dynasty such as Duryodhana and his 99 brothers belong to the type of people who believe in various, wrong teachings. Arjuna is different and can dispel his doubts and regain the spiritual knowledge he had already possessed.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
 दध्नाय नमः ॥ ४२ ॥

हस्त्यै नमः ॥
 {H\$`m{def~hb^mJœ`JqV à{V ॥ ४३ ॥

O Partha! Those with peripheral knowledge of the **Vedas** say that attaining heavens is the only goal of following the **Vedas**, ignoring the lofty goal of liberation (*moksha*). They only focus on temporary worldly riches and pleasures and believe that they are the end goals of conducting Vedic rituals. (2.42) (2.43)

Comments: As the **Vedas** can be interpreted in multiple ways, many focus only on the peripheral interpretation and conclude that the Vedic texts teach only rituals to appease lesser deities, which would result in achieving desired riches and materialistic happiness in this lifetime and enjoying heavenly fruits hereafter. Krishna categorically speaks against this viewpoint and strongly advises that the real purport of the **Vedas** is to help one achieve liberation, the state of everlasting, pure and complete bliss (*Moksha*), and not riches and heavens which are temporary. Using the **Vedas** only to reach the heavens would be like plucking a flower from a tree, without waiting for the flower to fully transform into a fruit (which represents *Moksha*).

^mJæ`àg°\$mZm V`m@növMVgm_ | V&
 ì`dg`mpË_H\$m ~{Ö... g_mYm Z {dYr`V V&& 44 &&

With their minds corrupted with such wrong thinking, they immerse themselves in pursuit of worldly pleasures and will not have the conviction to pursue correct knowledge and the concentration to focus their minds on the Lord. (2.44)

Comments: What is wrong in enjoying the riches achieved by performing Vedic rituals with sincerity? After all these fruits have been earned using legitimate, moral means as enunciated in the **Vedas**. Lord Krishna responds by saying that indulgence in such temporary pleasures will focus their minds only on material issues and their minds will not be able meditate on the Lord. Concentrated meditation is required to gain proper spiritual knowledge.

Vedas – Peripheral and Inner Meanings

ìJÊ`{df`m dXm {ZóJÊ`m ^dmOZ V&
 {ZÛÝÛm {ZË`gÎdñWm {Z`mJj_AmË_dmZ V&& 45&&

O Arjuna! Peripherally the **Vedas** appear to describe rituals that result in attainment of heavenly and worldly fruits made up of the three attributes. Do not aspire for these. Go beyond dualities (such as pleasure and pain). Focus your mind on the Lord Almighty and leave it to the Lord to help you attain your goals and to help you protect goals already attained. (2.45)

Comments: The Lord continues to teach about the real purport of the **Vedas**. In this verse, the Lord instructs that one should not focus on the peripheral meaning of the **Vedas** that appear to provide details of rituals to help achieve worldly fruits. These fruits and even heavens that one may achieve are borne out of material nature which is a mixture of three attributes – *sat*, *rajas* and *tamas*. As such, these are not permanent, and even if one reaches the heavens, one is bound to fall back to earth after expending merits from good deeds. One should detach oneself from *yoga* (striving for proscribed material entities not already owned) and *kshema* (protecting proscribed material entities already possessed). The real purport of the **Vedas** is to describe the nature of the Lord Almighty. One should focus on the Lord who will help one achieve everlasting bliss (*nirvana*).

`m d m Z W C X n m Z g d V ... g a ß b V m X H \$ ÿ &
V m d m Z g d f d X f ~ m ÷ U ñ ` { d O m Z V ... ÿ & & 46 & &

The benefit derived from a small body of water such as a well is better derived from a sumptuous water body such as an ocean. Likewise, benefits derived from following Vedic rituals with proper meaning are surely available for one with special knowledge who has realized the Lord Almighty. (2.46)

Comments: In the previous verses, it was indicated that the real purport of the **Vedas** is in understanding of the Lord and not in transient material benefits including attaining the heavens. It was made clear that one who goes by the peripheral meaning of the **Vedas** and performs rituals only to attain transient material benefits will never achieve everlasting bliss. A

question arises as to whether the seeker who goes by the inner meaning of the **Vedas** and realizes the Lord will be eligible for transient fruits such as the heavens. This verse answers that question through an example. Just as the benefits available from well water are available from a larger body of water such as a lake or an ocean, one who has realized the Lord by proper understanding of the **Vedas** will surely achieve transient benefits such as heavens, even when one is not focused on them.

Sri Raghavendra Swamy in his **Gita Vivruti** [GV] provides an explanation for the words *brahmana* (one who has realized the Lord) and *vijanatha* (one who has special knowledge) where both appear to mean the same thing. Sri Rayaru says that *vijanatha* indicates the one who has *paroksha* (or indirect) knowledge of the Lord and *brahmana* indicates one who has gone a step further and has realized *aparoksha* or direct knowledge of the Lord. In that sense, for one to obtain direct knowledge of the Lord, one must first start by learning the knowledge indirectly (through a qualified teacher, studying Vedic scriptures etc.).

Sri Rayaru provides a second meaning for this verse, by interpreting the Sanskrit terms *samplutodaka* and *udapana* differently. Earlier *samplutodaka* referred to a large body of water (ex: an ocean) and *udapana* referred to a small body of water (ex: well). Sri Rayaru provides a second meaning for these terms. *Samplutodaka* means the ocean that dissolves the universe during the grand dissolution and *udapana* refers to the Lord Almighty who protects the eternal entities in the universe such as souls, time etc. With this interpretation, the verse can also be translated to mean as follows: Whatever advantage (such as *dharma*, *moksha* etc.) is obtained through the Grace of the Lord Almighty who protects everything during the great dissolution of the universe, the same advantage will be accrued by a seeker who has realized the Lord through proper interpretation of the **Vedas**.

Duty is Worship

H\$ _Ê` d{YH\$mañV _m \ \$bf H\$XmMZ ĩ&
 _m H\$ _\ \$bhV^ _m V g“m@ñĒdH\$_{U ĩ&& 47 &&

You only have the right to do your duty, and never to its fruits. Never perform your duties with expectations of outcomes. At the same time, never think about relinquishing your duties. (2.47)

Comments: This is probably the most commented upon verse in the **Gita**. It answers the question as to the purpose of performing ones' prescribed duties when there is no guarantee of getting expected results. Even if someone does not see any immediate material benefits from performing ones' prescribed duties, such actions will please the Lord. They will result in one obtaining true knowledge about the Lord and eventually achieving everlasting bliss. This is implied in the first line of this verse. Another question that one can raise is the purpose of someone performing any action at all, as earlier in verse 2.45, it was stated that one should always focus ones mind on the Lord. The second line of this verse answers this question by stating that in addition to focusing the mind on the Lord, one must perform prescribed duties; otherwise, one will accrue sins due to relinquishing of duties. In addition to the philosophical reasons, we can all appreciate the fact that for a society to function smoothly, every one of us must play our assigned roles with diligence and sincerity. Such activities, especially when performed as an offering to the Lord, will help us receive the Lord's grace to help us in our spiritual journey. Lord Krishna is instructing Arjuna here that he should not shirk from his prescribed duty of fighting for a just cause, just because he is uncomfortable with the thought of losing his loved ones.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides a second meaning for this verse. He translates the phrase '*karma phala hetu*' (the entity responsible to grant fruits for actions) as the Lord Almighty, as He alone can grant someone the fruits. As per verse 2.45, one should not consider oneself identical to the

Lord as the Lord is supreme and He alone can grant one's wishes. The second interpretation of this verse is as follows: Arjuna! Individual souls can only perform prescribed duties. They do not have the ability to obtain the fruits by themselves. That ability is only with the Lord. Individual souls are quite different and are subservient to the Lord and hence one should never consider oneself as the Lord.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides convincing responses to many other deep, philosophical questions in his interpretation of this verse. Following is the summary:

- Even those who have already realized the Lord have to keep performing duties.
- For one who has already realized the Lord, any additional credit from performing duties will result in buoyant happiness in *moksha* (the level of bliss in *moksha* is dependent on the innate capabilities of souls, but additional credits will result in buoyant happiness, just like when milk boils over, the amount of milk does not change but the milk exhibits more buoyancy)
- No one is exempt from performing one's prescribed duties
- While this verse indicates that one should not perform duties with an expectation of the outcome, it is not prohibited for someone to perform activities with loftier expectations of spiritual knowledge and the Lord's Grace. One should avoid expectations of temporary, transient, material fruits.
- Although phrases such as '*swarga kamo yajeta*' prescribe rituals for fulfilment of mundane desires, the scriptures do not mandate such actions for fulfilment of desires.
- Major distinction between individual beings and the Lord in the context of duties and fruits:
 - Individual Beings: Have responsibility to perform duties. Cannot grant wishes.
 - Lord Almighty: Has no prescribed responsibility. Can grant wishes.

ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥
 {gÕç{gÕçm... g_m ^Ēdm g_Ēd ॐ J CÀ`V ॥ 48 ॥

O Dhananjaya! On your spiritual path (*yoga*), perform duties without attachments and expectations of results. The real *yoga* is performing one's duties without expectations and with equanimity. (2.48)

Comments: From verses 2.48 onwards, the Lord provides more details on the concept of *nishkama karma* (performing prescribed duties without expectations). In the previous verse 2.47, the Lord instructs Arjuna never to think of relinquishing prescribed duties. This verse responds to the question as to how one should perform prescribed duties. *Yoga* is having no expectations of results from duties performed *and* being equanimous to positive or negative outcomes. These are not two separate definitions of *yoga*.

Sri Vidyasagara Madhava Teertha has provided a detailed description of a *yogi* identified in this verse as –

(i) one whose mind and intellect are transfixed at the feet of the Lord with the knowledge of the Lord's omnipresence, omnipotence, and omniscience.

(ii) one who engages in actions without attachment to the act itself or the fruits of such actions.

(iii) one who engages in all activities only to please the Lord and as a service to the Lord.

(iv) one who, knowing fully well that everything is at the will and command of the Lord, accepts success or failure with equanimity.

XaU øda H\$_ ~{Ö`mJmX YZO` ॥
 ~Öm eaU_pÝdÀN> H\$nUm... \ \$bhVd... ॥ 49 ॥

O Dhananjaya! Performing duties with expectation of the outcome is very inferior to the task of attaining divine spiritual knowledge. Wretched are those whose motive is fruit of the action. Focus your mind on spiritual knowledge. (2.49)

Comments: In 2.46, it was indicated that one should avoid performing Vedic rituals for temporary gains but instead focus on the inner meaning of **the Vedas** to attain proper spiritual knowledge. In that sense, performing duties with expectation of material outcome is inferior to the task of attaining divine knowledge. This verse answers the question as to the reason for this distinction. One who is focused only on activities yielding temporary gains will realize sooner or later that such gains will not last and will start feeling miserable. Hence there is no point in performing activities with such expectations.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides an alternate interpretation for the second half of this verse in response to a question as to whether someone who has already attained spiritual knowledge can consider himself as one with the Lord. By interpreting the phrase *phala hetava* (the one who grants wishes) as referring to the Lord, Sri Rayaru says that even those who have attained spiritual knowledge will not claim identity with the Lord as such a claim would lead to unending misery.

~{Ö`°\$m OhmVrh C^ gH\$VXîH\$V î&
Vñ_úJm` `Á`ñd `mJ... H\$_g H\$meb_ î&& 50&&

One who has realized the Lord Almighty will be rid of the consequences of good or bad deeds. Therefore, focus on performing your duties with the goal of achieving divine, spiritual knowledge. This is the best path. (2.50)

Comments: In the previous verse 2.49, it was indicated that activities performed with expectations of material gains are inferior to the activities pursued in attaining divine knowledge.

That technique which steers one clear of worldly entanglement and ushers one towards the transcendental is ‘skill in action’ (*karmasu kauśalam*). In this verse, some of the special advantages of these superior activities are outlined. It is indicated that one who has realized the Lord will be rid of the consequences of good and bad deeds which is the essential last step in achieving *moksha*. A question that would arise naturally is about the reason for consequences of even good deeds to be nullified. Sri Rayaru in GV provides an answer. Good deeds are of two kinds – first one that leads to more clarity on divine knowledge and more exuberant happiness in *moksha* (*ishta punya*), and second ones (*anishta punya*) that do not. Credits from good deeds of the second kind must be used up in this world (in current or future births) while credits from the first kind of good deed will be carried forward till one achieves *moksha*. The Lord categorically states that among all activities, those that lead to attainment of divine knowledge are supreme.

Sri Rayaru [GV] provides a second interpretation for the second half of this verse. One can ask the question - If one feels that one can put in all required efforts to attain spiritual knowledge (which is the goal for achieving *moksha*), why should one perform activities without expectations on material outcomes? Sri Rayaru answers saying that only activities that are performed for the sole purpose of pleasing the Lord and obtaining divine knowledge will lead to *moksha*.

Sri Madinur Vishnu Teertha Swamiji in his **Gita Saroddhara** [BGS] indicates that this verse reflects the summary of entire chapter 2. This is very appropriate as in this chapter Arjuna in verses 2.4 to 2.8 had expressed the conflict in his mind about his course of action and requested Krishna for guidance. Krishna categorically states in this verse that one needs to perform ones prescribed duty with the goal of achieving divine, spiritual knowledge and that Arjuna needs to engage himself in fighting this holy war to protect his citizens.

H\$ _O ~{Ö`°\$m {h \ \$b È`³Edm _Zr{fU... ĩ&
OY _~Y{d{Z _°\$m... nX JÀNÝÈ`Zm \_` _ ĩ&& 51 &&

The wise who have learnt about the supremacy of the Lord Almighty, dedicate the fruits of their labour to the Lord and acquire direct, divine knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). They escape the cycle of births and deaths and reach the state of eternal bliss. (2.51)

Comments: In this verse, the Lord provides additional benefits of obtaining proper spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana* = direct, divine knowledge) which results in attaining *moksha*. One who reaches *moksha* will not only be devoid of sadness or blemishes but will also permanently escape the cycle of births and deaths. Lord Krishna is emphasizing the permanence of *moksha* as opposed to the transitory benefits of heavens. Sri Rayaru in GV explains the reason for interpreting the word ‘*manīṣiṇaḥ*’ as the one with direct, divine knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). The word ‘*manīṣi*’ means incredibly special knowledge, and direct divine knowledge certainly qualifies for this description.

`Xm V \_mhH\$ {bb ~{Öi`{V[aî`{V ĩ&
VXm JÝV{g {ZdX I mVi`ñ` IVñ` M ĩ&& 52 &&

Once your mind is cleansed of ignorant viewpoints, you will derive full benefits from the teachings you have heard so far and the teachings you will hear in future. (2.52)

Comments: Lord Krishna answers the question as to how and when one will be able to properly understand teachings delivered so far and the teachings yet to be delivered. One must first cleanse one’s mind of ignorant viewpoints which will then allow one’s mind to grasp the teachings properly.

I {V{dà{VnBm V `Wm ñWmñ`{V {Züb... ĩ&
g _mYmdMb ~{ÖñVXm `mJ \_dmñ`{g ĩ&& 53 &&

Once you develop conviction in spiritual teachings, your mind will become steadfast. At that time, you will be able to follow the path of divine knowledge. (2.53)

Comments: In 2.52, it was indicated that one must rid oneself of ignorant viewpoints. In this verse, the questions about what ignorant viewpoints really are and how one could be rid of them are answered. Ignorant viewpoints are those that are not supported by authentic scriptures such as the **Vedas**. Ones who have developed strong conviction about teachings from scriptures such as the **Vedas** will be able to rid themselves of ignorant viewpoints without any doubt. They will then be ready to focus their minds on the Lord which will lead to eternal bliss through the grace of the Lord.

Sri Rayaru [GV] provides a second interpretation of this verse based on Sri Madhwacharya's commentary in GTN where the phrase '*shruti vipratipanna*' is interpreted alternately as '*shruti visheshena pratipanna*' to mean – one with the right viewpoint based on authentic scriptures (*shruti*). Based on this, the verse can be interpreted to mean the following – The one who has realized the Lord based on proper understanding of the **Vedas** will have one's mind firmly placed on the Lord and will eventually attain *moksha* through the Lord's grace.

Equanimity and Mental Tranquility

AOZ CdmM Ĩ&

pñWVàkñ` H\$m ^mf g\_m{YñWñ` H\$ed Ĩ&

pñWVYr... qH\$ à^mfV {H\$_mgrV dOV {H\$‘ Ĩ&& 54&&

Arjuna said: O Keshava! What are the characteristics of a person who has developed unwavering conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge (*Stita Prajna*)? How does that person talk or sit or walk (in other words, why does that person need to engage in any activity)? (2.54)

Comments: This is perhaps one of the most widely quoted verse from the **Gita**. After listening to the Lord's teachings about the need for one to perform prescribed duties without expectations, focusing the mind on the Lord and related topics, Arjuna is now curious to know the characteristics of a person who has developed unwavering conviction (tranquil mind) in divine knowledge. It is interesting that he uses the term '*bhasha*' to mean characteristics instead of the more common word '*lakshana*'. Arjuna, by using the term '*samadhi*' (state of complete mental concentration on the Lord), has himself defined a characteristic (*lakshana*) of a person with deep conviction in divine knowledge. By using the word '*bhasha*', Arjuna is enquiring about the characteristic of such a person when that person is out of *samadhi* and is engaged in normal day to day activities. References to talking, sitting, walking etc., in this verse here imply normal day today activities. In other words, Arjuna wants to know how the person with firm resolve performs day to day activities (when not in state of *samadhi*).

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides a second interpretation for this verse as follows: Why does one who has achieved divine knowledge need to perform activities such as talking, sitting, walking etc.? Here the word '*kim*' is used to mean 'why'. In that sense it is a rhetorical question. Why should someone who has already achieved the state of *samadhi* and has developed unwavering conviction in the Lord indulge in any mundane, day to day worldly activities?

The Lord responds to Arjuna's questions in the remaining verses of this chapter which undoubtedly form the core teachings of the **Gita**.

Ir^JdmZdmM Ÿ&
 àOhm{V `Xm H\$m _mZ gdmZ nmW _ZmJVmZ Ÿ&
 AmĚ_Ÿ`dm@Ě\_Zm ViŸ... pñWVàkñVXmÀ`V Ÿ&& 55 &&

The Lord said: O Partha! One who has conquered mental blemishes such as desire and has focused mind on the Lord Almighty will achieve mental tranquility by the grace of the Lord. (2.55)

Comments: The Lord answers Arjuna's question 2.54, from 2.55 onwards till the end of this chapter. For the rhetorical question in the second line of 2.54, the Lord answers in verse 2.69. While desire is mentioned as a blemish that one needs to conquer, this also applies to other blemishes such as greed, anger, hatred etc. Note that desire here refers to worldly desires and not lofty desires such as achieving divine knowledge. Sri Rayaru [GV] explains the special reason for the use of the word 'manogatan' (mental) in this verse. Blemishes such as desire, greed, anger etc., originate in the mind. That being the case, what is the reason for using the qualifier 'mental' in 'mental blemishes'? The divine knowledge that one would attain by the grace of the Lord also manifests in the same mind. For the same mind to attain divine knowledge, it is necessary to be rid of worldly blemishes. It is to drive home the fact that divine knowledge also resides in the same mind that the qualifier 'mental' is used in this verse.

In verse 2.39, the Lord started out saying that He would teach the path (*yoga*) to obtain divine knowledge. However, in this verse, He is teaching the characteristics of a *yogi* who has already attained divine knowledge. How can this be reconciled? Sri Rayaru [GV] states that for a seeker interested in traversing the path towards divine knowledge, it is important to learn about the characteristics of *yogis* who have already successfully traversed that path.

X... I îdZ{Ô¾_Zm... g l f {dJVñnh... î&
drVamJ^`H\$mY... pñWVYr\_{ZéÀ`V î&& 56 &&

One whose mind is not depressed by distress or elated by happiness and who is devoid of desires or anger, or fear is known as steadfast in consciousness. (2.56)

Comments: In the next 3 verses, the Lord provides more details on the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In 2.55, worldly desire was mentioned as example of a blemish. Here that concept is extended to include other blemishes such as obsession, fear, and anger.

`...gdìṁZ{^ñZhñVîṁV àṁḡ e^ṁe^_ ṽ&
Zṁ{^ZÝX{V Z Ū{îṽ Vñ` àkṁ à{V{ḍVṁ ṽ&& 57 &&

One with deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnani*) will not have attachment in all dealings and will neither rejoice over pleasure nor experience hatred during distress. (2.57)

Comments: The reason for this equanimity in both pleasure and discomfort in such a person is the lack of attachment to worldly issues.

The previous verse 2.56 identified the absence of anger as one of the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility and this verse indicates the absence of hatred during distress as another characteristic. Sri Jaya Teertha in his PD clarifies that there is no repetition here as the absence of hatred in 2.57 refers to all situations (due to the use of the word *sarvatrāg*) including those where there may be reasons for such hatred.

`Xṁ ghaV Mṁ` H\$_ṁ@“ṁZrd gde... ṽ&
BpÝḌ`ṁUrpÝḌ`ṁWä`ñVñ` àkṁ à{V{ḍVṁ ṽ&& 58&&

A person of steady wisdom can easily withdraw sense organs away from objects of senses just as a tortoise withdraws its limbs at will. (2.58)

Comments: A person with mental tranquility can control sense organs from indulging in objects of sensory pleasures such as sound, touch, form, taste, and smell. The image of the tortoise which withdraws its limbs at will is used to signify the ease with which such a person is able to control sense organs.

{df`m {d{ZdV'V {Zamhman` X{hZ... ' &
agdO agm@B`ñ` na ÑîQm {ZdV ' && 59 &&

By fasting, one can reduce the ability of one's body to consume and digest food, but not the cravings to indulge in tasty food. Those cravings can only be diminished by realizing the Lord Almighty. (2.59)

Comments: The next 3 verses are about sense control. By practicing self-discipline such as fasting, one experiences reduced power in the five sense organs of perception such as eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and skin. However, the craving experienced by the mind to indulge in sense pleasures does not diminish. This can only happen when one experiences a vision of Lord Almighty.

Sri Rayaru [GV] also provides an alternate meaning to this verse by interpreting the word '*rasa varjam*' to mean desires in objects of all sensory pleasures except taste. This means that by fasting one may experience loss of desire in the objects of sense pleasures such as sound, form, smell, and touch but not in the sense object of taste. This can only be overcome when one experiences a vision of Lord Almighty. This interpretation is also consistent with practical experience as when one ages and loses power and interest in seeing, listening, hearing etc., the desire to taste good food never goes away. In summary, a seeker should strive to achieve control over all sense organs and mind.

`VVm Ø{n H\$m'V` néfñ` {dn{üV... ' &
hpÝÐ`m{U à _mWr{Z hap'V àg^ _Z... ' && 60 &&

O Son of Kunti! It is the nature of sense organs to get attracted to sense pleasures. Despite many efforts, even learned ones experience their sense organs swaying strongly. (2.60)

Comments: If one can understand that one needs to control one's sense organs from indulging in sense pleasures (discipline in consumption -

pratyahara) and focus one's minds on attaining spiritual knowledge, one may be able to conquer their sense organs. In that case why should one undertake difficult activities such as fasting - *nirahara* etc.? This verse answers this question by stating that sense organs are extremely strong and can exert control on the minds of even learned ones. It is the nature of sense organs to cause turbulence in one's mind. Hence, one must undertake difficult rituals such as fasting on special days etc., in addition to spiritual studies and try to overcome the influence of sense organs on one's mind.

The sense organs and the mind are inert objects. A question then arises as to how these inert objects can exert such control over each other. One must remember that the sense organs, while inert, are activated by the Lord resident in every soul based on the innate nature of that soul. So, it is the responsibility of the individual soul to try and control the activities of the sense organs.

Vṁ{Z gdm{U g`â` `°\$ AṁgrV _Ēna... ṽ&
de {h `ñ`pÝĐ`ṁ{U Vñ` àkṁ à{V{đVṁ ṽ&& 61&&

One should control one's sense organs from indulgence with a firm conviction on the supremacy of the Lord. Such a person will indeed attain divine knowledge, (2.61)

Comments: From previous discussions, it appears that one needs to control one's sense organs to attain divine, spiritual knowledge. However, it also appears that one needs to have possessed such divine, spiritual knowledge to be permanently free from the control of sense organs. This appears to be a circular argument and hence is logically untenable (*anyonyashraya dosha*). How can this be reconciled? Sri Rayaru [GV] points to this verse for the answer. One must try and control one's sense organs while at the same time focus mind on the Supreme Lord. This will allow the mind to move towards concentrated meditation (*dhyana*) which allows one to undertake difficult sense control tasks such as strict fasting,

and eventually conquer the sense organs. Such a person is now ready to absorb divine, spiritual knowledge paving the way for *moksha*.

Sri Rayaru [GV] clarifies that for one to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*), in addition to achieving full control over the sense organs, a seeker also needs to conquer emotions such as desire, hatred etc., as described later in verse 2.64.

Dangers in Sensual Indulgence

Ü`m`Vm {df`mZ ng... g“ñVfnOm`V ĩ&
g“mV gOm`V H\$m\_... H\$m\_mV H\$mYm@{^Om`V ĩ&& 62&&

H\$mYmX ^d{V gâ_mh... g_mhV ñ_{V{d^_... ĩ&
ñ_{V^eX ~{ÖZme ~{ÖZmeX àUí`{V ĩ&& 63&&

One who keeps contemplating on sense pleasures develops an attachment and obsession with them, which leads to desire in experiencing such pleasures. This desire in turn leads to anger in the event of not being able to satisfy these desires. Anger leads to delusion and clouds one's mind about right and wrong. This delusion leads one to forget injunctions against forbidden activities. This forgetfulness in turn leads to failure in intellectual judgement. Loss of intellect results in one's downfall. (2.62) (2.63)

Comments: In verse 2.63, it was stated that one should focus ones mind on the Lord while striving to achieve self-control to conquer the sense organs. In verses 2.62, 2.63, 2.64, the Lord outlines the chain reaction that would ensue from loss of self-control and the emotional impact of attachment/aversion or likes/dislikes (*raga/dvesha*) leading to ones downfall (and eventual fall into hell). Understanding of this chain reaction will help one to develop equanimity in likes and dislikes.

The chain reaction is as follows: contemplation on sense pleasures -> obsession -> desire -> anger -> delusion -> forgetfulness -> loss of

intellect -> destruction. Forgetfulness could be of two types. One would be forgetting knowledge about avoiding activities prohibited in the scriptures and the other would be to forget societal norms such as not usurping properties owned by others. As indicated in 2.56, one who has realized the Lord will have conquered these emotions, but a seeker on the spiritual path will have to strive to control these emotions, or else he/she will experience the state indicated in the chain reaction. The primary cause of the chain reaction is the inability to manage *raga*, and *dvesha*. This aspect is further explained in the next verse.

amJÛf{d`°\$ñV {df`m{ZpÝÐ`üaZ Ý&
AmĚ_dí`{dY`mĚ_m àgmX_{YJÀN{V Ý&& 64 &&

àgmX gdX... I mZm hm{Zañ`mnOm`V Ý&
àgPMVg_m øme ~{Ö... n`d{Vð{V Ý&& 65 &&

One, whose sense organs are under control and are not perturbed by the effects of likes/dislikes, attachment/hatred, will partake in just enough sense indulgence for physical health and, through self-control will experience peace of mind. (2.64),

One whose mind is at peace will quickly absorb divine, spiritual knowledge (*aparoksha jnana*). Then, such a person will be rid of all miseries. This concept is well known through the scriptures. (2.65)

Comments: These two verses indicate the benefits one would accrue by controlling the emotions of likes and dislikes. The benefits are – victory over sense organs and mental peace. In 2.61, it was indicated that one who has conquered sense organs will attain direct, divine (*aparoksha*) knowledge. However, sense control itself will not directly lead to attainment of divine knowledge. Sense control leads to mental peace allowing one to practice concentrated meditation. This leads to attaining direct, divine knowledge. So the immediate advantage of self-control is mental peace which eventually leads to direct, divine knowledge in a serial

manner. It is also clarified that one who has achieved control over sense organs can indulge in sense activities just enough to maintain physical wellbeing. In verse 2.59, it was indicated that one would need to undertake difficult tasks such as fasting to achieve self-control. Here it is clarified that one does not need to completely avoid consuming foods as one has to ensure physical wellbeing. It is possible to indulge in activities such as consuming minimum amount of required food while still exerting control over the sense organs.

In summary, the sequence of events that would unfold from achieving self-control are as follows: Self-control (over sense organs) -> mental peace -> concentrated meditation -> divine knowledge -> elimination of sadness (due to evisceration of sins) -> liberation.

ZmñV ~{Öa`°\$ñ` Z Mm`°\$ñ` ^mdZm V&
Z Mm^md`V... em{VaemVñ` H\$V... g l _ && 66 &&

One who does not have control over the mind cannot absorb spiritual knowledge. Such a person also cannot meditate peacefully. How can one achieve liberation without meditation? How can one enjoy bliss without liberation? (2.66)

Comments: The next two verses describe the perils of not being able to control one's mind. If one can achieve divine, spiritual knowledge through scriptural studies and analysis, why would one need to control ones mind? This verse answers by stating that one who does not control the mind will not be able to practice concentrated meditation without which one will not be able to absorb difficult concepts in the scriptures. Also, in this verse it is stated that one who does not achieve liberation (*moksha*) cannot enjoy bliss. One can question the reason for explicitly stating that eternal bliss can only be enjoyed by those in *moksha*. It must be noted that in 2.65, it was stated that when one is liberated, one will be rid of unhappiness. This verse clarifies that in *moksha* not only will one be rid of misery, but one will also enjoy pure bliss.

BpYĐ`mUm {h MaVm `Y_Zm@Z{dYr`V ĩ&
 VXñ` ha{V àkm dm`Zmd{dmā^{g ĩ&& 67 &&

The mind which follows sense organs that go after sense pleasures will be swayed just like a ship gets swayed in an ocean by strong winds. This leads to loss of intellectual judgement and also knowledge derived through studies. (2.67)

Comments: This verse makes it very clear that even one who has learnt a lot through study of scriptures and contemplation of scriptural concepts will not be able to benefit from such knowledge if one is unable to control the mind and the sense organs. Mere acquisition of scriptural knowledge without exercising control over the senses and the mind amounts to just book knowledge. The mind is easily swayed. If sense organs pursue sense pleasures, the mind will follow them and will sway just like a boat in an ocean and loses direction when faced with strong winds.

The example of a ship getting swayed by strong winds brings to memory an episode in the life of Sri Madhwacharya. Acharya was once meditating on the seashore near Udupi when he saw a ship caught in a violent storm. The people on the ship were crying for help. Acharya waved his holy fabric (*kavi shati*) towards the ship, at which the ship immediately stabilized on the waters and came safely ashore. The travelers on the ship who were rescued by Acharya were very grateful and offered him precious gems on board the ship, but Acharya was content with just a lump of sandstone (*gopi chandana*) that was used to tie the ship's mast. Inside the sandstone was a beautiful idol of Sri Krishna which was worshipped by Goddess Rukmini and Lord Brahma. Sri Madhwacharya carried that idol and installed it in Udupi where it can be seen even today! We can see the relevance of using the example of a ship swaying in the ocean in this verse considering this episode. Our body is like a ship that we are using to cross the ocean of *samsara*. Inside our body, Lord Krishna resides in our hearts just like the idol of Sri Krishna was inside the sandstone. Just as the

travelers on the ship did not know the value of the sandstone piece which had the idol of Sri Krishna in it, we too do not appreciate the presence of the Lord in our hearts. Just as the travelers on the ship faced violent turbulence due to strong winds, we also feel great perturbation in our minds due to strong swaying of our sense organs. The travelers saw Sri Madhwacharya and cried for help. Acharya rescued them immediately. Similarly, if we turn to Sri Madhwacharya (an incarnation of Sri Vayudeva) asking for help in traversing this ocean of *samsara*, he will rescue us and land us safely in *moksha*.

Vñ _mÚñ` _hm~mm {ZJhrVm{Z gde... ĩ&
BpÝĐ`mUrpÝĐ`mWä`ñVñ` àkñ à{V{đVm ĩ&& 68&&

O Mahabaho (Arjuna, one with strong arms)! One who controls the sense organs from straying towards sense objects will attain deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge. (2.68)

Comments: In the 4 verses, starting from verse 2.55 to 2.58, the Lord described the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In the 9 verses from 2.59 to 2.67, questions about the nature of such a person were answered. This verse is a concluding summary of the above 9 verses. The sequence of stages for such a person to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge are sense-control -> peace of mind -> mental concentration -> spiritual study and contemplation -> conviction in knowledge -> concentrated meditation -> divine, spiritual knowledge.

Characteristics of a Realized Soul

`m {Zem gd^VmZm Vñ`m OmJ{V g`_r ĩ&
`ñ`m OmJ{V ^Vm{Z gm {Zem ní`Vm _Z... ĩ&& 69 &&

On the issue of spiritual knowledge where everyone is in the dark, a realized soul is wide awake (and aware) and on worldly issues on which everyone is wide awake (and fully engaged), the realized soul stays in the dark. (2.69)

Comments: In this verse the Lord is comparing the interests and knowledge of a normal worldly person and a realized person. Most people immersed in daily, worldly affairs are completely in the dark and have no interest in learning about the attributes of the Lord, whereas a realized soul is very much alert, awake, and aware of the attributes of the Lord. Conversely, while most people are focused on worldly matters, indulging in sense pleasure, a realized person stays in the dark (has no interest in such matters).

A realized soul is completely immersed in the Lord and has no interest at all in worldly matters. A question then arises about deities such as Indra, Surya, Agni etc., who are realized souls but have an active role in worldly matters as they activate the sense organs of living beings. If, as realized souls, they avoid taking interest in worldly matters, how can the world function? Sri Rayaru [GV] answers this question by stating that the nature of a realized soul referred to in this verse does not apply to deities. It applies to souls who have achieved self-realization but are not part of the group of deities who have specific roles.

Amn`\_mU'Mbà{Vđ g\_Đ\_mn... à{depÝV`ÛV İ&
VÛV H\$m_m` à{depÝV gd g empÝV_mßZm{V Z H\$m_H\$m_r İ&& 70 &&

Just as an ocean does not rise with constant inflow of water and continues to take in rivers, one who is able to absorb worldly matters without getting attached is destined for liberation. One who is always focused on chasing desires can never achieve peace. (2.70)

Comments: It was stated in verse 2.69 that a realized person has no interest in worldly matters. However, there are instances of such people indulging in sense activities such as eating, hearing, seeing etc. This verse explains this apparent contradiction by clarifying that just as an ocean does not rise with the inflow of river waters, a realized person who indulges in sense activities, purely to maintain physical wellbeing, does not get attached to such consumption.

{dhm` H\$m\_mZ `... gdmZ n_müa{V {Z...ñnh... }&
 {Z__m {ZahH\$ma... g empÝV_{YJÀN{V }&& 71 &&

One who is rid of ego and arrogance and who performs worldly activities without desires will achieve peace and eternal bliss. (2.71)

Comments: In the previous verse, it was stated that a seeker must exercise sense control and partake in consumption activities only to maintain physical wellbeing. In this verse, it is further clarified that even when partaking in such consumption, one should do so with detachment and with firm conviction that one does not have any ownership or independence in action with regard to consumables and consumption.

Efm ~÷r pñW{V... nmW ZZm àmb` {d_ø{V }&
 pñWEdm@ñ`m _ÝVH\$b@{n ~÷ {ZdmU_ÀN{V }&& 72 &&

O Partha! This is the character of one who has deep conviction in divine, spiritual knowledge. Such a person will not experience misery in worldly matters and in due course will reach the Lord's abode. (2.72)

Comments: In verses 2.55 to 2.69, the Lord explains the characteristics of a realized soul in response to Arjuna's query in verse 2.54. This verse is a conclusion of that discussion. Sri Rayaru clarifies in GV that a realized soul will reach the Lord's abode only after getting rid of the effects of good and bad deeds (*prarabdha karma*). Sri Rayaru further clarifies that the reference to Brahma here is related to the Lord (*Para Brahma*) and not to the four-faced deity Brahma, based on the use of the qualifier *nirvana* (meaning one without material body = Lord Almighty as *vana* = *bana* refers to material body).

Summary of Chapter 2

With the context for the teachings in the **Gita** established in Chapter 1, the actual sermon of Lord Krishna to Arjuna (and through Arjuna to the

rest of humanity) begins in Chapter 2. Seeing Arjuna in a pitiable condition not wanting to wage the war, Krishna asks Arjuna why he wants to avoid performing his prescribed duties and thereby risk losing respect in society. Such an abdication of responsibility is not worthy of a great prince like Arjuna who had a stellar reputation for fighting for justice all his life (2.2-2.3). Arjuna, who so far wanted to avoid war out of compassion and attachment to his kith and kin, now reasons that Bheeshma, Drona and others are not mere family members and teachers whom he holds in very high esteem. They are also worthy of worship. However, Krishna's questioning opens some doubts in his mind, and he informs Krishna that his mind is conflicted, and he is unsure about the path forward. He surrenders to Krishna, requests to be considered as a student and given guidance (2.4-2.8). Given that Arjuna's doubts are deep rooted, Lord Krishna proceeds to deliver a very detailed sermon to him covering all aspects of life such as the relationship between the Lord and individual souls, responsibilities of everyone in society, concept of devotion to the Lord, transient nature of life, cycle of births and deaths and many more topics which prove to be a summary of critical teachings from all scriptures such as the **Vedas** and great epics such as the **Ramayana**, the **Mahabharata** etc (2.11-2.71).

At this stage, one can expect several questions as to the context and content of the **Gita**. Firstly, why would Krishna get into great details about life, the universe, the relationship between the Lord and individual souls and such spiritual issues when all that was needed was some timely, practical advice to Arjuna to get on with fighting the war. The reason Krishna had to get into such great details is that Arjuna had developed deep rooted doubts about his duties and responsibilities, and he had to be convinced about the need to perform his duties without getting excessively attached to his near and dear ones. Secondly, one would wonder if the battlefield was the right venue for such heavy philosophical discourse which should normally occur in a serene, quiet environment. Again, it is normal for many to seek guidance when they come to a crossroad and are about to implement actions with grave repercussions. These are the very times when one needs proper spiritual guidance. Some would question as to

how such a lengthy sermon can be delivered when millions of soldiers are about to start a war. Krishna's conversation with Arjuna runs quickly as Arjuna is an evolved soul and absorbs the concepts very quickly. Finally, some wonder how Arjuna who is known as an incarnation of deity Indra could be ignorant and develop such fundamental doubts about his duties and responsibilities. At the end of Krishna's teachings, Arjuna responds saying that by Krishna's grace, his doubts have been cleared, his memory is back, and he is clear about his duties and responsibilities (18.73). The fact that his memory was back, implies that Arjuna had proper knowledge about his duties earlier but for some reason his mind was covered with delusion. It was the Lord's Divine Will that Arjuna would undergo temporary loss of memory to set the stage for his doubts and questions, which then gave Him an opportunity to use Arjuna as an instrument to teach the **Gita** to all of the mankind. Lord Krishna then advances many powerful reasons for Arjuna to stop worrying about the harm the war could cause to his loved ones. Firstly, his elders and teachers such as Bheeshma and Drona were not worthy of grieving for as they had supported Duryodhana, the evil king, whose army had to be destroyed to establish order and righteousness. Despite their good nature, these elders were blind to Duryodhana's evil intentions and hence were not deserving of sympathy (2.11). Secondly, if Arjuna was worried that these elders would be permanently destroyed, Krishna reminds him that the body and the soul are separate, and that their souls would live on. Further, based on the good deeds they had performed, they would achieve heaven. So, it was unnecessary to grieve over them (2.12). Thirdly, just as a body undergoes various stages in life such as childhood, youth, old age etc, death is also a natural stage for everybody. As such, these elders would die one day or the other, and no amount of grieving could prevent that (2.13). Fourthly, just as one does not grieve about throwing out old, worn-out clothes as they are replaced by new, good clothes, one should not grieve over a worn-out body that will eventually be replaced by a new one (2.22). Basically, Krishna teaches Arjuna that he must perform his rightful duties and any excuses coming in the way are untenable.

Verses 2.20 to 2.24 give us a description of the nature of individual souls which are indestructible, and have no beginning or end etc. As opposed to individual souls, the nature of the Supreme Soul (Lord Almighty) is briefly described in verses 2.17, 2.25 and 2.29. The Lord who pervades everywhere, is eternal, and does not experience destruction of the body (as His body is transcendental), and is full of auspicious attributes and is devoid of any blemishes. He is superior to individual souls and hence is worthy of worship. One should perform ones prescribed duties as an offering to the Lord without expectations. This paves the way for one's liberation. Coming to the practical aspects of Arjuna's decision to relinquish arms, the Lord emphasizes the need for Arjuna to perform his prescribed duties, as for a *kshatriya*, there is no loftier duty than waging a just war. Arjuna has been handed a great opportunity to perform his duty and he should not waste this chance. If he were to withdraw from war, purely out of compassion to near and dear ones, nothing would prevent his enemies from concluding that Arjuna was afraid to fight, and they could question his valor. Finally, Krishna tells Arjuna that he has nothing to lose by waging the war. If he wins, he gets to rule the kingdom and eventually goes to heaven hereafter for diligently performing his duty. If he loses and dies, he will attain heavens for his conviction and efforts (2.31-2.37). From verses 2.12 to 2.38, Krishna imparts Arjuna knowledge (*sankhya*) about the Lord and individual souls. From verse 2.39 onwards, He teaches Arjuna the methods and procedure (*yoga*) for acquiring such knowledge after which Arjuna would be able to perform his prescribed duties with conviction, realize the Lord, get over worldly bondage and achieve the state of eternal bliss (*moksha*). In verses 2.42 -2.45, the Lord teaches Arjuna the real purport of the **Vedas** - that one should focus on the deeper meanings and not get carried away by peripheral meanings. The real purport of the **Vedas** is divine, spiritual knowledge of Lord Almighty. In verses 2.45-2.51, the Lord discusses the concept of *nishkama karma*, that is performing prescribed duties without expectations. Specifically, in verse 2.50, the Lord categorically states that the best path for one to achieve divine, spiritual knowledge is for one to focus on performing one's assigned duties as an offering to the Lord without expectations on the outcome (*nishkama*

karma). Such a realized soul would be rid of the consequences of good and bad deeds and would be eligible for liberation. Among all activities, those that lead to attainment of divine knowledge is supreme. In verses 2.52 and 2.53, it is stated that in order to absorb proper teachings, one needs to cleanse one's mind of conflicting, ignorant, and inconsistent viewpoints not based on scriptural truths. In verse 2.54, Arjuna asks Krishna about the characteristics of a person with such a tranquil mind. In the 4 verses, starting from verse 2.55 to 2.58, the Lord describes the characteristics of a person with mental tranquility. In the 9 verses from 2.59 to 2.67, questions about the nature of such a person are answered. The Lord concludes the sermon in Chapter 2 by stating in 2.72 that such a person will not experience worldly miseries and in due course will reach His abode.

॥ B{V {ŪVr`m@Ūm`... ॥

End of Chapter 2